STUDY IN CONTRAST

If micro-management is a barometer, Narendra Modi seems to be one up on the other national party in this respect as well. The prime minister has been spending long hours at every meeting of the BJP's central election committee (CEC). Before the release of its first list, he is said to have immersed himself in the selection process from around eight in the evening till well past three in the morning. Why, he did not even take a bio break in that time, a Union minister tells us, and drank only three glasses of *nariyal paani* in that time. Rahul Gandhi, by contrast, has skipped at least the past three consecutive meetings of his party's CEC. His call for senior leaders to contest the Lok Sabha polls also seems to be boomeranging on him. Murmurs have been rising that he, and his sister Priyanka, contest from Uttar Pradesh, which the siblings seem unwilling to do. With mum Sonia Gandhi opting for the Rajya Sabha route, there will be no representation of the Gandhi family in the Lok Sabha from the state since 1999. How the mighty have fallen. ■



ANI

▶ JHARKHAND

Family Feud

Kingship knows no kinship. At no time does it become more evident than during elections. On March 24, as the BJP gave a ticket to Sita Soren, the estranged sister-in-law of former Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren, to contest from the Dumka Lok Sabha seat, it became clear that the party wanted to shake the Soren family's hold from its bastion. Sita, who quit the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) and her seat to join the BJP on March 19, is the widow of Shibu Soren's eldest son Durga Soren, who died in 2009. Her departure came in the wake of sharp differences with Hemant's wife Kalpana. Hemant is currently in judicial custody. Kalpana was not appointed CM after the Enforcement Directorate arrested him in January, allegedly because of Sita's vehement opposition to the idea. ■



PTI

the two were brothers and supported each other in their personal lives, he too is campaigning for his aunt.

Support for their grand-uncle comes also from Rohit Pawar, grandson of Pawar Sr's elder brother Dinkarrao aka Appasaheb and Pawar faction MLA from Karjat-Jamkhed constituency.

Pawar Sr's sister Saroj Patil, wife of the late Peasants and Workers Party (PWP) leader and former minister N.D. Patil, has also come out in niece Supriya's support. Other members of the clan, including from Ajit's branch of the family, are also expected to throw their weight behind the senior Pawar and his daughter, further isolating Ajit in a battle that will determine the political future for the warring sides.

Family troubles aside, Ajit is facing the heat also from allies. Vijay Shivtare, a former minister from the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, has announced he is throwing his hat into the ring and launched a blistering attack against the Pawars. Former minister and BJP leader Harshavardhan Patil, who hails from neighboring Indapur, has also openly expressed his discontentment with Ajit.

What of Pawar Sr himself? Denying rumours that the octogenarian may contest for the Lok Sabha, a Pawar loyalist said his energies were instead focused on getting daughter Supriya elected to Parliament. The senior Pawar is also trying to mend fences with erstwhile foes, such as former minister Anantrao Thopte, whose son Sangram is a three-term MLA from Bhor, which is part of the Baramati Lok Sabha constituency.

On his part, Ajit has tried to underplay the differences within the wider Pawar parivar, saying this was not an election in an extended family or village but for the Lok Sabha. "This is an election that will determine the future of the 140 crore people of this country. We must see it from that angle. At least I see it that way," he said. ■